HYDRATION

How much fluid people need day to day, during exercise and in the heat, and how to spot dehydration early.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General wellness information, not medical advice. It does not replace care from a doctor, nurse, pharmacist or other qualified professional. **Talk to your health-care provider before starting a new exercise, diet or health plan, especially if you have a medical condition.**

1. HOW MUCH?

There is no single number for everyone. The National Academies set a general daily target for **total water from all drinks and food**:

WHO	TOTAL WATER PER DAY	NOTES
Adult men	About 3.7 liters (about 15 cups)	About 20% usually comes from food; the rest from drinks.
Adult women	About 2.7 liters (about 11 cups)	More during pregnancy and breastfeeding.

Most healthy people get enough by **drinking when thirsty and with meals**. Needs go up with heat, exercise, illness (fever, vomiting, diarrhea) and pregnancy or breastfeeding. For emergency storage, plan 1 gallon per person per day. *(TL-02)*

2. AM I DRINKING ENOUGH?

GOOD SIGNS

- Urine is pale yellow, and you pass it regularly through the day.
- You rarely feel very thirsty.

EARLY DEHYDRATION

- Thirst; dry mouth; dark yellow urine or not much of it.
- Headache, tiredness, dizziness, muscle cramps.

GET MEDICAL HELP FOR

- Confusion, fainting, a racing heartbeat, or no urine for 8 hours or more.
- Vomiting or diarrhea that won't let someone keep fluids down, especially babies, young children and older adults.
- Signs of heat stroke: call 911. *(TL-05)*

3. EXERCISE AND HEAT

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
Everyday exercise	Drink water before you start, sip during, and drink after. For under an hour of ordinary exercise, water is enough.
Long or very sweaty activity	Over an hour, or heavy sweating: a sports drink, or salty snacks with water, replaces the salt you lose.
Working in the heat	Drink about **1 cup (8 oz) every 15 to 20 minutes** while working, even if you're not thirsty. Rest in the shade.
Don't overdo it	In the heat, don't drink more than about **48 oz (1.5 quarts) an hour**. Drinking far too much water can dangerously lower the salt in your blood.

4. GOOD HABITS

- Carry a refillable bottle.
- Drink a glass of water with each meal.
- Water is the best everyday choice. Milk and unsweetened tea or coffee count too.
- Fruit and vegetables (watermelon, oranges, cucumbers, lettuce) are mostly water.
- Limit sugary drinks; they add calories without filling you up.
- Alcohol makes you lose fluid; alternate with water.
- Older adults feel thirst less: drink on a schedule.
- If your doctor limits your fluids (heart or kidney conditions), follow that advice instead.

5. DAILY TRACKER

Check one box per cup (8 oz). Set your own goal with your provider if you have a medical condition.

DAY	CUPS	URINE COLOR (PALE / DARK)
MON	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	
TUE	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	
WED	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	
THU	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	
FRI	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	
SAT	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	
SUN	☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐	

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine: Dietary Reference Intakes for Water, Potassium, Sodium, Chloride and Sulfate. nationalacademies.org
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: About Water and Healthier Drinks; Heat Stress: Hydration (NIOSH). cdc.gov
3. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine): Dehydration. medlineplus.gov

IMPORTANT: People with heart, kidney or liver conditions may have fluid limits. Follow your provider's advice.